

Medicinal Actions & Uses A strongly bitter herb, chiretta is powerful medicine for a weak stomach, especially when linked to nausea, indigestion, and bloating. It is taken in small, frequent doses to improve appetite and digestive function. For hiccups, small, frequent doses are taken with honey. Like most bitters it reduces fever, cooling the body and increasing blood flow to the liver. In Ayurvedic medicine the herb is used for *pitta* (fire) conditions, and is best known as the major herb in *mahasudarshana churna*—a standard mixture of more than 50 herbs prescribed for fevers such as malaria, liver problems, gallstones, and indigestion. Recently it has been used with other herbs to treat allergies.

Research The xanthenes are thought to be antituberculous and antimalarial. Amarogentin has a protective action on the liver.

Caution Avoid in digestive hyperacidity.

Symplocarpus foetidus (Araceae) Skunk Cabbage

Description Unpleasant-smelling perennial plant growing to 30 in (75 cm). Has a thick tuberous rootstock, cabbage-like leaves, and small purple flowers on a hooded spike.



Skunk cabbage is a foul-smelling plant with a powerful expectorant action.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to northern North America, skunk cabbage thrives in meadows, swamps, and marshes. The root and rhizome are collected in autumn or early spring.

Parts Used Root, rhizome.

Constituents Skunk cabbage contains a volatile oil, serotonin (5HT), and resins.

History & Folklore The Winnebago and Dakota peoples used the expectorant and antispasmodic skunk cabbage root to treat asthma

and bronchitis. The root was also employed as a poultice to draw splinters and thorns, to heal wounds, and to relieve headaches. It was much used in America in the 19th century.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Skunk cabbage continues to be used primarily as an expectorant, treating cases of asthma, bronchitis, and whooping cough. It is also taken for upper respiratory problems such as nasal congestion and hayfever. Less commonly, skunk cabbage is used as a treatment for epilepsy, headaches, vertigo, and rheumatic problems, and to stop bleeding.

Cautions Handling fresh skunk cabbage may cause the skin to blister. Excessive doses can bring on nausea and vomiting, headaches, and dizziness.

Syzygium cumini (Myrtaceae) Jambul

Description Evergreen tree growing to 33 ft (10 m). Has lance-shaped leaves and green-yellow flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation A native of southern Asia and Australia, jambul is now also found in tropical regions of Africa. The tree is cultivated commercially for its fruit and is propagated from seed or semiripe cuttings in summer. It requires well-drained soil and plenty of sun. The fruit is harvested when ripe.

Parts Used Fresh and dried fruit, seeds.

Constituents Jambul contains triterpenes, anthocyanins, flavonoids, and volatile oil.

History & Folklore Jambul is a typical example of a medicinal plant that is both food and medicine. The fruit when ripe has the scent and taste of a ripe apricot and is eaten as a preserve. While both fruit and seed have a tonic and astringent effect on the digestion, the seeds have long traditional use in Ayurveda as a preventative and treatment for diabetes.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Following traditional use, jambul continues to be employed for a wide variety of health problems. The powdered seed is commonly taken to treat diabetes and the frequent urination that accompanies it, as well as a remedy for mouth ulcers, stomachache, diarrhea, dysentery, and worms. Case reports over the last 100 years and more recent pharmacological research supports the use of jambul for diabetes and poor blood glucose control. It is thought to lower blood-sugar levels by about 30%.

Related Species Many other closely related species have notable therapeutic activity. Cloves (*Eugenia caryophyllata*, p. 97) are taken for digestive problems and to treat infection. *Syzygium gerrardii* from South Africa and *Luma chequen* from Chile are used to treat coughs and congestion.

Tamarindus indica (Fabaceae)

Tamarind

Description Evergreen tree growing to 80 ft (25 m). Has fine compound leaves, clusters of orange-yellow flowers, and brittle gray-brown seed pods (fruit) containing up to 12 round seeds.

Habitat & Cultivation While native to Madagascar, the tamarind is now cultivated in many of the world's tropical regions, including the Caribbean, India, Southeast Asia, and China.

Parts Used Fruit, leaves, seeds.

Constituents Tamarind contains 16–18% plant acids (including nicotinic acid—vitamin B₃), a volatile oil (with geranial, geraniol, and limonene), sugars, pectin, 0.8% potassium, and fats. Vitamin C was formerly believed to be among the constituents of tamarind, but this is now being disputed.

History & Folklore Sailors ate tamarind fruit as a nourishing complement to their otherwise starchy diet, in the belief that eating the fruit would prevent scurvy. However, it appears that tamarind does not in fact contain vitamin C. Tamarind is a major ingredient in many chutneys and condiments, notably Worcestershire sauce.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Tamarind is a wholesome and cleansing fruit that improves digestion, relieves gas, soothes sore throats, and acts as a mild laxative. However, mixed with cumin and sugar, tamarind is also prescribed as a treatment for dysentery. It is given for loss of appetite and nausea, and as a stomach tonic and mild laxative. It may help with nausea and vomiting in pregnancy. In southern India, tamarind soup is taken to treat colds and other ailments that produce excessive phlegm. In Chinese medicine, it is considered a cooling herb, appropriate for treating “summer heat.” The fruit is also given for loss of appetite, for nausea and vomiting in pregnancy, and for constipation. The seeds’ traditional use as an antivenin in snake bite has been partly confirmed in laboratory research.

Self-help Use Sore throats, p. 311



Fruit

Tanacetum vulgare (Asteraceae)

Tansy

Description Strongly aromatic perennial growing to 3 ft (1 m). Has an erect stem, feathery compound leaves, and clusters of yellow disk-shaped flowerheads.

Habitat & Cultivation Found throughout temperate zones in the northern hemisphere,